



in their last but shaky citadels

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WEST BENGAL

The Last Gasps

From Mamata to Maoists to the mafia, the enemy is multiplying against the Marxists

By Abhijit Dasgupta

There is nothing too shameful about being vanquished. Being written off, however, does not have any fig leaf. The tragedy of the Left Front in West Bengal is precisely that—it is badly in need of something to hide its shame. From a Front that rode to power on a massive mandate 32 years ago, it has now become a mockery of itself. Worse, it is being humbled by a party which had just one MP, the redoubtable Railways Minister Mamata Banerjee, in the last Lok Sabha. Now the Trinamool-led Opposition tally stands at 20 while the Left Front has 16 MPs out of the 42 seats in the state. In three decades of rule lapsing slowly but steadily into misrule, the Front, mainly Big Brother CPI(M), has proved what democracy actually means.

The tolerance of Bengal had been tested for so long that finally the people rose to write off a party which just a decade ago was its very own.

To add insult to injury, on October 20, in perhaps the most daring attack by the Maoists in Lalgarh, they moved into a relatively peaceful area of Sankhrail in West Midnapore and abducted an officer-in-charge, killed two senior police officers and looted a bank. Coming as it does shortly after Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's morale-boosting trip to Delhi, where he apparently got a free hand from Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram to tackle the Maoists, the radicals seemed to have rubbed the Government's nose into the ground.

This is not good news for a Government which is already at war with itself, with the partners fighting it out